

Hypertension (High Blood Pressure)

What is Hypertension?

Hypertension is a condition where blood pressure in the arteries is persistently elevated. Normal blood pressure is below 120/80 mmHg. Hypertension is diagnosed when readings consistently exceed 140/90 mmHg.

It is called the 'silent killer' because most people have no symptoms even when blood pressure is dangerously high.

Symptoms

Most people with hypertension have no symptoms. When symptoms do occur they may include: severe headaches, especially in the morning; nosebleeds; vision changes or blurred vision; chest pain or tightness; shortness of breath; dizziness or lightheadedness; blood in urine.

A hypertensive crisis (blood pressure above 180/120) is a medical emergency with symptoms of severe headache, confusion, chest pain, and difficulty breathing.

Medicines

ACE inhibitors (enalapril, lisinopril) relax blood vessels by blocking a hormone that narrows them.

Angiotensin receptor blockers (ARBs) such as losartan and telmisartan work similarly to ACE inhibitors.

Calcium channel blockers (amlodipine, felodipine) relax blood vessel walls.

Diuretics (hydrochlorothiazide, furosemide) reduce fluid in the body to lower pressure.

Beta-blockers (metoprolol, atenolol) slow heart rate and reduce blood pressure.

Emergency Actions

If blood pressure exceeds 180/120 with symptoms: call emergency services (112 or 911) immediately.

Have the patient sit calmly and rest. Do not allow physical exertion.

If prescribed emergency medication (e.g., clonidine), administer as directed by doctor.

Do NOT give aspirin unless chest pain suggests a heart attack.

Monitor breathing and consciousness. Prepare to perform CPR if needed.

What You Should Do

Eat a low-salt, heart-healthy diet (DASH diet). Reduce sodium to less than 2300 mg per day.

Exercise at least 30 minutes most days. Lose weight if overweight.

Quit smoking and limit alcohol. Manage stress through meditation or yoga.

Take prescribed medicines consistently. Never stop medications without consulting your doctor.

Monitor blood pressure at home regularly and keep a log for your doctor.